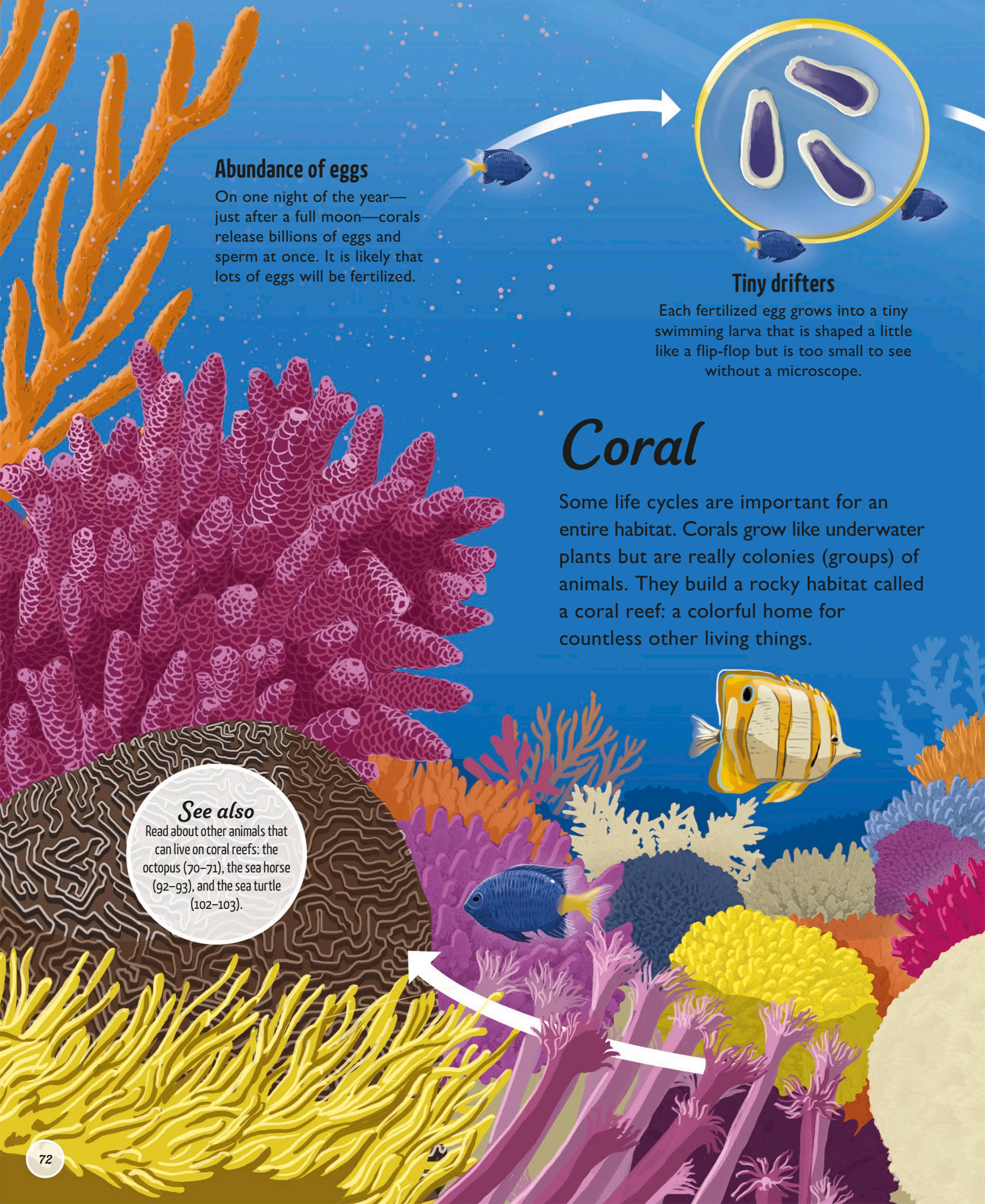




Abundance of eggs

On one night of the year—just after a full moon—corals release billions of eggs and sperm at once. It is likely that lots of eggs will be fertilized.



Tiny drifters

Each fertilized egg grows into a tiny swimming larva that is shaped a little like a flip-flop but is too small to see without a microscope.

Coral

Some life cycles are important for an entire habitat. Corals grow like underwater plants but are really colonies (groups) of animals. They build a rocky habitat called a coral reef: a colorful home for countless other living things.

See also

Read about other animals that can live on coral reefs: the octopus (70–71), the sea horse (92–93), and the sea turtle (102–103).